

KF42 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Last week we started to learn the skill of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. This technique balances your autonomic nervous system, opens new brain paths, and clears your mind for rest or creative effort. It also relaxes your body and calms your emotions. You can read about this technique on the web and discover more of its great benefits. In our KF training, we practice this breathing method to focus our minds and explore our feelings about limitations.

In our last lesson we practiced **Alternate Nostril Breathing** guided by detailed instructions. In this lesson, however, less instruction will be offered so that you have more time to practice.

Alternate Nostril Breathing

Assume a meditation posture and breathe naturally for thirty seconds, allowing your body to regulate your breath. (*Pause for 30 seconds*)

Now, using your right hand, press your thumb against your right nostril, closing it off as you inhale. For the exhale, release your thumb and press your index or middle finger on your left nostril, exhaling through your right nostril. Inhale through your right nostril and then close it off, exhaling through your left nostril. Basically, you switch nostrils on the exhale. As you experiment with this technique, breathe naturally or use the **Three-Part Breath**. We will practice for three minutes. Begin. (*Pause for 3 minutes, announcing each minute as it passes*)

And pause. You might begin your meditation time with the **3-Minute Breathing Space** and then move to a few minutes of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**.

Our hymn for KF Confession 10 is *O Worship the King*. This hymn was written in 1833 by Sir Robert Grant, who served his country as a politician, CEO, lawyer, and governor.

O, worship the King all glorious above,
And gratefully sing His wonderful love!

Our Shield and Defender, the Ancient of Days,
Pavilioned in splendor and girded with praise.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

We begin to experience real liberty when we practice KF Confession 10:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

Here is a quote from *The Harvard Business Review*:

If success is a catalyst for failure because it leads to the ‘undisciplined pursuit of more’, then one simple antidote is *the disciplined pursuit of less*. Not just haphazardly saying no, but purposefully, deliberately, and strategically eliminating the nonessentials. Not just once a year as part of a planning meeting, but constantly reducing, focusing and simplifying. Not just getting rid of the obvious time wasters, but being willing to cut out really terrific opportunities as well. Few appear to have the courage to live this principle, which may be why it differentiates successful people and organizations from the very successful ones.² (Pause)

In our culture, we think of ASAP as an acronym for ‘as soon as possible’, implying an urgency that often overrides priorities and ignores the flow. In the last few lessons, Nancy has encouraged you to think of ASAP in a new way: *Ask, Simplify, Adventure, and Prioritize*. Ask God for direction. Simplify your life like a soldier going into battle. Adventure into new territory that may threaten your Idol’s taboos. Set priorities that honor your discoveries. As the *Harvard Business Review* says, reduce, focus, and simplify for success. Get rid of the obvious time wasters in your life but, also, cut out the really terrific opportunities that do not support your priorities.

Really terrific opportunities can be dangerous; they tempt us to ignore our real limitations and waste our hard-won MATH. We then find ourselves committed to things that require money we don’t have, abilities we haven’t demonstrated, time that’s committed elsewhere, and a level of health that is not ours. We neglect our self-care, run on too little sleep, allow stress to build up, and drive ourselves back into slavery. If you find yourself regularly following this pattern, you might acknowledge the enslaving hold that your Idol has on you and then begin to tackle it with ASAP.

Realistic goals take into account the person you actually are and set priorities about what you will do with what you already have. Although you may be tempted to support your pride system with illusions of who you could be or what you would do with what you don’t have, your real business is to honor your limitations and rejoice in the truth of what you have to work with today. Use well what you already have. The truth of how capable you actually are is revealed in the evidence of how well you handle today.

Your resources are limited, and you will want to use them wisely. Wisdom includes recognizing the limitation of cycles and the natural ebb and flow of the tide. The wisdom of simplicity budgets and

allocates resources for those days when the tide goes out. If you build margins between your limitations and the normal, periodic drain of life's events, you will be able to make effective use of these inevitable low tides. Low tides are times to rest, restore, and establish a new working platform. In order to do that, you need to have stored resources.

You only have one life here. What will you do with it? It is your business to budget the real resources that are yours. All human creatures have to consider their resources of money, abilities, time, and health. You only have so much money, so much training, so much time, and so much physical, mental, and emotional energy, or strength. Whenever you are faced with a decision, from the smallest thought about what to eat or wear to the larger issues of retirement planning or raising a child, do the MATH. M is for money. A is for abilities. T is for time. H is for health. Whenever you make plans for your life or hope to take on a new project or possibility, do the MATH.

In the next few weeks, we will learn to do the MATH and look at how limitations support gratitude and glorious living. This week, you might explore these questions in your **Flow Pages**: *In what direction do I want my life to go? Where is my money, ability, time, and health going today? Where am I in debt? What are my real limitations? What move toward my real glory would I like to make? What is my first priority?* Practice ASAP: Ask for help. Simplify your life. Adventure and explore. Then, once the truth about yourself and your situation is revealed, reshape your priorities.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, teach me to honor my real limitations and do the MATH. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

In the Gospel of Luke, chapter 14, Jesus teaches us about limitations. He wants us to remember that we are just creatures with limited resources. It is our job to make the most of those resources, and that takes planning. Our text for this lesson, which we will read in Nancy's paraphrase, is **Luke 14:25–33**. These verses speak about budgeting all of our limited resources.

²⁵Many people were going forward together with Jesus, and He turned to them and said,
²⁶"If anyone comes to Me to be My student and does not hate their own father and mother and wife and children and brothers and sisters, and even their own idealized life, that person is not yet able to become My student. ²⁷Whoever refuses to take their own cross into their own hands and come after Me does not yet have what it takes to be My student. ²⁸Look at it this way. Which of you, when you want to build a tower, does not first sit down and do the MATH to see if you have enough resources for its completion? ²⁹If you have laid a foundation but are unable to finish the tower because you did not do the MATH, everyone watching you will laugh at you, ³⁰saying, 'That idiot began to build and then did not have the resources to fulfill his plan!' ³¹Or, what king, when he sets out to meet another king in battle, will not first sit down and take counsel to determine whether he, with ten thousand men, has the MATH to encounter the one coming against him with

twenty thousand men? ³²And if that king finds that he does not have the MATH, he prepares ahead for the possibilities and sends his senior ambassadors to the stronger king to ask for terms of peace. ³³So then, if you will not say goodbye to what you depend upon, you are not yet ready to be My student.”

Take a deep breath.

In this passage, Jesus is essentially talking about doing the MATH before seeking first the kingdom of God and His righteousness.³ Are you willing to make God and His way of doing things your first priority? If you want to make Him your highest priority, then you have to set everything else and everyone else at a lower priority. That is what He means when He tells you that if you want to become His disciple, you must hate your own idealized life, your old family systems, your prideful illusions, and whatever you imagine you have control over or claim to own. You must also hate your community when it interferes with or actively opposes your priority to follow Jesus. You can imagine the shock of this teaching in a culture that had very strong feelings about family and possessions. Jesus isn't being selfish or harsh when He tells us to hate everyone close to us. He is actually being kind by telling us the truth right from the beginning. Without a strong sense of priority, something or someone will eventually turn you away from the path of orientation.

How and when you are distracted reveals the quality of your allegiance to God and your own trustworthiness. As your allegiance and trustworthiness grow, you will become more sensitive to the effects of misorientation. You will be able to quickly recognize when you have disconnected from God and have stepped out of the flow. That misoriented condition of strain and chaos will feel unnatural and destructive. You will begin to hate it. This is a healthy use of the emotion of hate.

Your Idol Self does not want to accept that you have real limitations. That's why this teaching is particularly distasteful and even painful for your Idol. Furthermore, the Idol Self hates the reality that as mortal creatures we spend most of our lives in simple maintenance—sleeping, eating and eliminating, caring for children, working, record keeping, commuting, and making repairs. Simple maintenance does not feel glorious, and the Idol craves feeling glorious.

Jesus encourages you to be wise and do the MATH before you explore any new possibility. He wants to support your success, so He reminds you that you are a creature with real limitations. Learn how to do your MATH. Assess your real money, abilities, time, and health. Then, based on the real evidence of your limited resources, plan your days to give yourself the best chance to build an increasingly courageous, glorious life that reveals the character of your Creator—a life that cannot be built on the magic of your imagined strengths or idealized dreams. Say goodbye to your pride. Learn to assess your real limitations of money, abilities, time, and health. Then, in the light of that assessment, evaluate your projects. When faced with your real limitations, try gratitude. Those limitations can work for you. Present your puzzles to the Lord. Ask for direction. Simplify by humbly letting go of prideful illusions about yourself and your situation. Adventure into reality, and develop healthy priorities.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, teach me to do the MATH for my own life. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair*, how do you feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* If you are unaware of having any feelings right now, you can observe your experience with compassion. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to simply rest in your awareness. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider a limitation that seems restricting or unfair*. What sensations are there? Allow your body to talk to you. *(Pause)* You might say to yourself, “This is what discouragement feels like in my body” or “This is what frustration feels like.” You might feel relief in your body, or you might feel nothing at all. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this limitation that seems restricting or unfair*. Are you comfortable or uncomfortable while you observe? *(Pause)* Do you feel compelled to judge this limitation as good or evil? What do you believe about it? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Do you feel a similar restriction in other areas of your life? *(Pause)* Observe whatever you are experiencing as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath or the Dragon Breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore your limitations.
- Welcome the wise Holy Spirit of truth, who is training you to live in reality.
- Welcome where you are today and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what this limitation reveals. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁴

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to make things go my way.
- As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to fulfill my family system.
- As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to defend what is mine.
- As I am trained by this limitation, I let go of the compulsion to get my dreams magically fulfilled.

(Pause for 30 seconds)

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for drawing us together for this time of training and healing. Guide us by the power of our real limitations into the glory of our unique design. This week, teach us about our MATH as we reorient our lives to flow more effectively in our karis relationships and to further our connection with our True Self and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, invite the group to respond to this meeting)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *O Worship the King* by Sir Robert Grant (1779–1838), www.youtube.com/watch?v=RAyKmYD2Zg8.

² hbr.org/2012/08/the-disciplined-pursuit-of-less.

³ Matt. 6:33.

⁴ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.